

1 The Geometry of the Margin

1.1 Why Pages Have Borders

A margin is not wasted paper. It is the frame that lets the eye know where a line begins and where it safely ends, and without it a reader's gaze slides off the text block and loses its place. Early scribes, working before the conventions of the printed book had settled, left margins so generous that the written area occupied barely half the sheet. They were not being wasteful; they were buying legibility, and they were leaving room for the reader's own hand to answer back.

The proportions that govern a well-set page were worked out long before anyone could state them as arithmetic. A page feels balanced when the outer margin is wider than the inner one, because two facing pages share their inner margins and the eye reads the pair as a single spread. Make the inner margin too wide and the spread splits in two; make it too narrow and the text vanishes into the binding. The rule is invisible when it is obeyed and glaring the moment it is broken.

1.1.1 A Note on Gutters

The gutter is the inner margin measured across the bound edge, and it is the one dimension a designer cannot recover after the fact. A book sewn too tightly buries its gutter text in the curve of the spine, and no amount of careful typesetting on the flat page can rescue a line the reader cannot physically flatten into view.

1.2 The Size of the Type

Type that is too small tires the eye within a page; type that is too large turns a paragraph into a staircase the reader must climb. The comfortable range is narrower than most people expect, and it depends less on the height of the letters than on the length of the line they form.¹ A long line forces the eye to travel so far that it struggles to find the start of the next one.

¹A line of roughly sixty to seventy characters is the figure most often cited; the body of the line, not the body of the letter, is what governs comfort.

This is why a wide page is so often set in two columns rather than one. The column is not a decorative choice but a correction: it cuts an unreadably long measure into two readable ones. The cost is a second boundary the eye must cross, and a reader pays that cost gladly because the alternative is worse.

2 The Life of a Book

A book is read far less often than it is shelved, and a binding that survives a century of shelving has done most of its job. The boards guard the text block from light and dust; the spine takes the wear of every removal and return. A book that is beautiful but fragile is a book that will be admired and not used, and a working library has little patience for objects it cannot open.

The paper itself is the slowest clock in the room. Rag paper, made before the industrial era, ages gently and can outlast the building that houses it. The wood-pulp paper that replaced it carries its own acid and slowly burns itself brown from the inside. A reader who opens a book from either era is, without thinking about it, reading the chemistry of the page as much as the words upon it.